



ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

VEHICLES traverse the reopened part of Mulholland Highway between Kanan Road and Sierra Creek Road.

RISKY STRETCH OF L.A. HIGHWAY REOPENS

County hopes new measures can prevent crashes on portion of Mulholland Highway.

By CLARA HARTER

For more than six years, adrenaline junkies have yearned for the moment that, once again, they can career around the serpentine corners of a stretch of Mulholland Highway with the crisp mountain air rushing through their hair.

Their wait came to an end Tuesday as a 2.4-mile section of the road known as “the Snake” slithered back to life.

The area of the highway roughly between Kanan Road and Sierra Creek Road has been closed to vehicle traffic since early 2019 after it was charred in the Woolsey fire and further damaged by winter rains.

Before the closure, the Snake was known for attracting speeding motorcyclists and car races and frequent collisions.

Now, with a new set of safety improvements in place, L.A. County officials are hoping the road can shed its dangerous reputation.

This includes new curve-warning signs, tightened intersections, updated road stripes, safety bollards and rumble strips designed to slow traffic. The California Highway Patrol will perform traffic enforcement and establish routine patrols to deter nighttime racing and takeovers, and the L.A. County Sheriff’s Department will issue citations to vehicles parked illegally along the edge of the road.

“We have kept this road closed following the Woolsey Fire for as long as state law allows, and we remain committed to keeping Mulholland Highway safe for everyone,” L.A. County Supervisor Lindsey Horvath said in a statement. “My office has directed Public Works to continue evaluating the area for additional improvements and report back in six and twelve months.”

In 2016, before the road closure, the Board of Supervisors voted to ban vehicles stopping along both sides of the highway in an attempt to eliminate races that drew spectators.

During the Woolsey fire, which scorched some 97,000 acres of Malibu over 13 days, the Snake’s guardrails melted, pavement burned and a bridge was destroyed.

The road reopened for pedestrians and cyclists in April 2020 after infrastructure repairs.

[See Highway, A8]

California aims to protect minors working on farms

State agencies will collaborate to crack down on violations of child labor laws.

By ROBERT J. LOPEZ

California officials said they are launching new enforcement actions to protect underage farmworkers, including enhanced coordination among two state agencies charged with inspecting work conditions in the fields.

The actions follow an investigation by Capital & Main, produced in partnership with the Los Angeles Times and McGraw Center for Business Journalism, which found that the state is failing to protect underage farmworkers who labor in harsh and dangerous circumstances.

Thousands of children and teenagers work in California fields to provide Americans with fresh fruit and vegetables. Although laborers as young as 12 can legally work in agriculture, many described being exposed to toxic pesticides,

dangerous heat and other hazards.

The new enforcement efforts will be overseen by the state Labor and Workforce Development Agency, which directs key agencies charged with regulating child labor and worksite safety laws, officials said.

Officials said the state’s Bureau of Field Enforcement, which regulates child labor and wage and hour laws, is developing plans to conduct joint operations with an existing agricultural enforcement task force as [See Farmworkers, A8]

Some in Mexico welcome U.S. force

By KATE LINTHICUM AND JARED OLSON

MEXICO CITY — Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum has repeatedly insisted that she will not allow the U.S. military to fight drug cartels inside her nation’s borders.

“It’s not going to happen,” Sheinbaum said last month after President Trump yet again threatened such an operation. “We don’t want intervention by any foreign government.”

But while Sheinbaum passionately defends her na-



GERARDO VIEYRA NurPhoto

PROTESTERS against drug cartel-related violence clash with police last month in Mexico City’s Zocalo.

tion’s sovereignty, recent polls and interviews from across Mexico show that a significant number of people here in fact welcome more American involvement in their country’s battle against organized crime — including having U.S. boots on the ground.

Slightly more than half of Mexicans surveyed by polling firm Mitofsky said they believe “U.S. authorities should enter Mexican territory to fight organized crime and arrest its leaders.” A third of respondents to a poll by El Financiero news- [See Mexico, A3]

No kill order was given, says admiral

By STEPHEN GROVES AND LISA MASCARO

WASHINGTON — A Navy admiral commanding the U.S. military strikes on an alleged drug boat in the Caribbean told lawmakers Thursday that there was no “kill them all” order from Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth, but a stark video of the attack left grave questions as Congress scrutinizes the campaign that killed two survivors.

Adm. Frank “Mitch” Bradley appeared for a series of closed-door classified briefings at the Capitol as lawmakers conduct an investigation after a report that he ordered the follow-on attack that killed the survivors to comply with Hegseth’s demands. Legal experts have said such a strike could be a violation of the laws of military warfare.

“Bradley was very clear that he was given no such order, to give no quarter or to kill them all,” Sen. Tom Cotton (R-Ark.), who heads the Senate Intelligence Committee, said as he exited a classified briefing.

Although Cotton defended the attack, Democrats who were also briefed and saw video of the survivors being killed questioned the Trump administration’s rationale and said the incident was deeply concerning.

“The order was basically: Destroy the drugs, kill the 11 people on the boat,” said Washington Rep. Adam Smith, the top Democrat on the House Armed Services Committee.

Smith, who is demanding further investigation, said the survivors were “basically two shirtless people clinging to the bow of a capsized and inoperable boat, drifting in [See Attack, A6]

Affordability concerns sink Trump ratings

Voters across the board are increasingly worried about the economy, polls show.

By MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — Weeks after suffering bruising election losses across the country, and facing an unusually tight special congressional race in ruby red Tennessee, President Trump told reporters Tuesday that a “fake” national narrative has taken hold of an economy in trouble.

Americans are employed and consuming more than ever, he said. Foreign tariffs and investments are bringing in trillions of dollars. “The word ‘affordability,’” Trump added, “is a Democrat scam.”

It was a message in defiance of stark public opinion polling that shows a clear majority of Americans, across all ages and demographic groups, increasingly concerned with the state of the economy and the president’s approach.

A Fox News poll released before Thanksgiving found that 76% of respondents viewed the economy negatively. Surveys conducted since the holiday put Trump at the lowest point of his second term and lower than any of his predecessors at this point in their second term since President Nixon. Gallup found that 36% approve of his job performance, with 60% disapproving, and an Economist/YouGov poll saw only 32% of

Americans support Trump’s response to the country’s affordability crisis.

“Trump was not shy about promising to lower prices on day one,” said William Galston, chair of the governance studies program at the Brookings Institution. “Not only do they not see prices coming down, but they don’t believe he is focused on those problems, taking the type of bold steps they expected him to take on the economy.”

Four key voter blocs — young adults 18 to 29 years old, Latinos, moderates and independents — are among those that swung most dramatically to Trump in last year’s election and are most likely to respond to changing circumstances. “He is doing badly with all of them,” Galston said.

“There wasn’t a realignment that was a permanent shift of sympathy — they were dissatisfied with President Biden’s performance, so they decided to give Trump another chance,” Galston added. “But he didn’t own them. He just rented them. And the rent’s coming due.”

Republicans holding the line

The downward trend in support for Trump started over the spring once a trickle of revelations on the president’s ties to disgraced financier Jeffrey Epstein, as well as his increasing focus on foreign conflicts, began dividing his core base of supporters.

Gallup now finds [See Trump, A6]

Tangible memories in brick and mortar

Artist helps the public process the January fires by creating memorial out of salvaged chimneys

By Tyrone Beason



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

L.A. ARTIST Evan Curtis Charles Hall recently completed the painstaking relocation of the chimneys for his memorial project.

High above Pacific Coast Highway in Malibu, Kraig Hill stood on a concrete slab and gave a tour of a home that is no longer there. Destroyed in the January wildfires, the home Hill grew up in now exists only as a blueprint in his mind.

A concrete Buddha used to gaze toward the horizon from its perch beneath a coral tree. Behind the house was the swimming pool that Hill, a semi-professional musician and producer, and his partner Hashi Clark, an artist, converted into a concert venue. They used to invite guests to sit in the shallow end to listen to musician friends playing in the deep end.

Murky rainwater now filled the pool-slash-auditorium. The Buddha survived, but the coral tree that shaded it was gone. Only one small piece of the house remained: a brick fireplace with its chimney, situated near windows with bird’s-eye views of the Pacific Ocean below.

The fireplace was the living room’s only heat source. Hill and his family would gather around it when he was young to keep warm on chilly winter days.

[See Chimneys, A12]

Justices rule for Texas voting map

The Supreme Court allows the redrawing of congressional districts to favor Republicans in 2026. **NATION, A6**

Famed alligator Claude dies at 30

Born in 1995, rare albino gator drew a worldwide following and was San Francisco’s unofficial mascot. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Paramount pans Warner in dispute

Letter from studio’s lawyers accuses the media company of favoritism toward one bidder: Netflix. **BUSINESS, A10**

Weather
Lots of sunshine.
L.A. Basin: 71/47. **B6**

